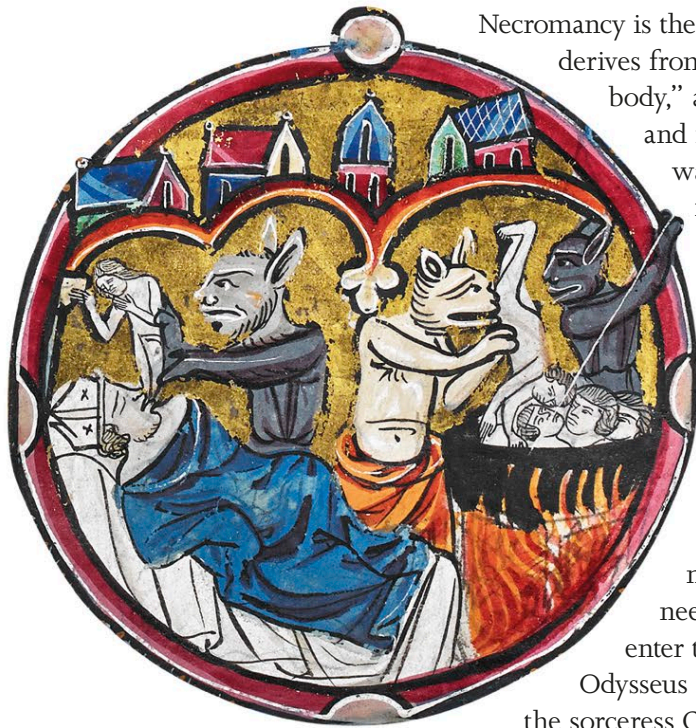


SUMMONING DEMONS AND THE DEAD

medieval necromancy



▲ **Demons and souls**
This detail from a 13th-century French manuscript describes a scene from the book of Maccabees in the Tanakh (Hebrew bible) in which demons take people's souls and put them in a cauldron.

Necromancy is the magic of the dead. The word derives from *nekros*, Greek for “dead body,” and *manteia* for “divination,” and it was used at first to mean a way of acquiring knowledge from the dead. In medieval times, it came to mean summoning the spirits to divine the future, gain hidden knowledge, bring someone back to life, or use the dead as a weapon.

Early beliefs

For the ancient Greeks, necromancy was the ritual needed for a living person to enter the underworld. In the *Odyssey*, Odysseus follows a ritual outlined by the sorceress Circe to visit the underworld and find out what will happen on his voyage back. The Greeks did not believe that the dead knew more than the living, but in other cultures the view was that the dead were all-knowing. In the Bible, the Witch of Endor summons the spirit of the prophet Samuel for King Saul, and Samuel foretells Saul's death, which happens later that day.

► Necromancer at work

In this illuminated letter “M” from a 1481 manuscript copy of Pliny the Elder's *De Naturalis Historia*, a necromancer draws a magic circle and lays a flask of oil, a bell, and a handbook of ritual magic within it.

Centuries later, around 600 CE, the scholar Isidore of Seville believed that the dead spirits the necromancers called on were not the dead at all but in fact were demons. Medieval necromancy—also referred to as nigromancy (literally, “black magic”)—was seen as an illicit art and defined as the act of summoning spirits and demons. Necromancers themselves insisted that they were not making pacts with the Devil but using God's power to bring spirits and demons under control.

Growing interest in ritual

From the 12th century onward, translations of Arabic texts into Latin, such as the *Picatrix* (see pp.82–83), sparked scholarly interest in elaborate ritual magic. The *Munich Manual of Demonic Magic* described ways to trace circles on the ground and fill them with symbols—the circle providing a protective space for the necromancer. However, magical demonic power could come at a price, and sometimes an animal had to be sacrificed for the spirits to communicate.

POPE SYLVESTER II (945–1003)

The wizard pope

In the 1120s William of Malmesbury claimed that the French Pope Sylvester II (shown talking to the Devil, right) had been a black magician. A century later, in *Lives of the Popes*, Martin the Pole described Sylvester as a necromancer who had sold his soul to the Devil. In fact, Sylvester, originally Gerbert of Aurillac, was one of the greatest scholars of the age, and introduced Arabic numerals and the astrolabe to Europe. He was also an expert in music and built several organs.

